

YOUNG LIFE

A young tiger is dependent on its mother for food for the first year or so of its life. By the time it is 2 years old, it will have enough power, strength, and experience to be able to catch prey for itself. It may start breeding in its fourth or fifth year, and lives on average until the age of 8–10.



TIGER IN ACTION

Tigers in the Ranthambhore reserve in northwest India have been known to charge into lakes after sambar deer and become fully submerged with their prey. The tigers in this area have also been reported to have killed and eaten crocodiles.

Panthera tigris

Tiger



Length 4½–9¼ ft
(1.4–2.8 m)

Tail 28–43 in
(72–109 cm)

Weight 165–720 lb
(75–325 kg)

Location S. and E. Asia

Social unit Individual

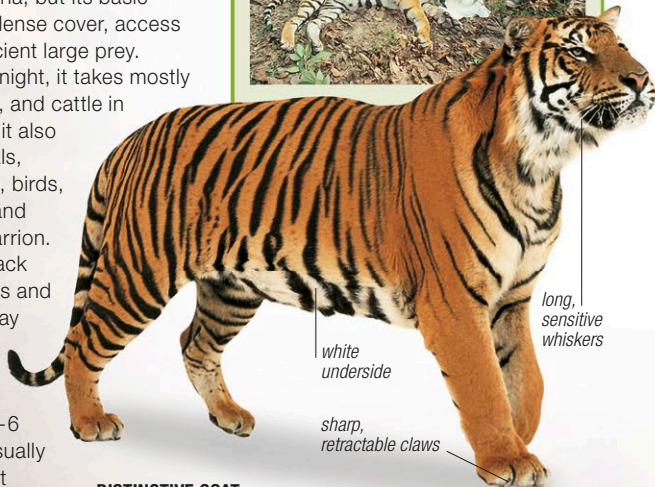
Status Endangered



The tiger is the largest member of the cat family, and its orange coat with black stripes and white markings is instantly recognizable. Its size, coat color, and markings vary according to subspecies. Although 8 subspecies are recognized historically, 3 have become extinct since the 1950s. And out of the 5 remaining, 3 are critically endangered and 2 are endangered. The geographical distribution of the tiger once extended as far west as eastern Turkey, but it is now restricted to pockets of southern and eastern Asia. The tiger's habitat varies widely, from the tropical forests of Southeast Asia to the coniferous woodlands of Siberia, but its basic requirements are dense cover, access to water, and sufficient large prey. Hunting mainly by night, it takes mostly deer and wild pigs, and cattle in some regions, but it also eats smaller animals, including monkeys, birds, reptiles, and fish, and readily feeds on carrion. Tigers will also attack young rhinoceroses and elephants. They may eat up to 88 lb (40 kg) of meat at a time and return to a large kill for 3–6 days. Tigers are usually solitary, but are not necessarily antisocial. A male is occasionally seen resting or feeding with a female and cubs, and tigers may also travel in groups.

CONSERVATION

Between 1900 and 2000, tiger numbers fell from an estimated 100,000 to 3,500—approximately the figure today. After decades of poaching, habitat loss, and loss of prey, scattered populations survive only in eastern Russia, China, Sumatra, and in southern Asia from Vietnam to India. Although protected in most areas, tigers are still killed to meet the demand for bones and body parts, which are used in oriental medicines. Programs to save the tiger have met with mixed results, with limited successes set against a trend of overall decline. Radio collars (see below) and antipoaching patrols give these vulnerable predators at least some protection in the wild.



DISTINCTIVE COAT

The Bengal tiger, *Panthera tigris tigris*, the most common of the subspecies, exhibits the classic tiger coat: deep orange with white undersides, cheeks, and eye areas, and distinctive black markings. Tiger stripes, which range from brown to jet-black, vary in number, width, and tendency to split. No 2 tigers have the same markings.

LIVING TIGER SUBSPECIES



SUMATRAN TIGER

The smallest and darkest of the tiger subspecies is the Sumatran tiger, *Panthera tigris sumatrae*. Only about 600 are thought to exist today.



SIBERIAN YOUNGSTERS

The Siberian tiger, *Panthera tigris altaica*, is the largest subspecies, and the lightest in color, with the longest coat. Its numbers may be as low as 150–200.